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BONE OF CONTENTION
A stray dog in Ahmedabad

GUJARAT/ STRAY DOGS

CANID SHOTS

By Jumana Shah

A dog may be man's best friend, but a spate of canine attacks in India in recent months have sort of undone that adage for many. A handful of states—Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh—had thus far been the source of most stray dog attack headlines in India. But three recent incidents have put the spotlight on yet another state: Gujarat. In October, Parag Desai, the executive director of the Wagh Bakri Tea Group, lost his life due to a brain haemorrhage he suffered when he tripped while trying to escape some dogs in Ahmedabad. A month later, in November, stray canines attacked a two-year-old outside his house in the Juhapura area of the city. The very next day, another four-year-old child playing outside his house in Surat was struck by dogs. Both children suffered multiple injuries but were saved by passersby. These incidents came just months after dogs mauled a two-year-old child in Morbi to death.

In Ahmedabad, the municipal body has received as many as 7,675 complaints of stray canines so far this year. Gujarat ranks fifth in the country after the four aforementioned states in terms of the total number of dog attack cases. Four agencies have been tasked with sterilising and vaccinating stray dogs in Ahmedabad, and approximately 130 canines are sterilised every day, say Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation (AMC) officials. The sterilisation-vaccination drives started as far back as 2006. But according to data submitted in the Lok Sabha, Gujarat reported 169,000 dog bite cases even in 2022. And the total population of dogs in the state was reported to be 931,000 according to the 2019 count, a 10 per cent increase since 2012. By the yardstick of population control, clearly, a lot remains to be done.

There's the opposite view too: the question of 'human safety vs animal welfare' has divided urban Indians for long now. Keren Nazareth, senior director, companion animals and engagement at the Indian arm of the Humane Society International, says living with stray dogs should be accepted as a reality, and the solution is not to get rid of them but to understand their behaviour. "Urban planning is wholly human-